

FIGURE 4.7 Snapshot, “Audre Lorde’s Trip to West and East Berlin in 1984.” (Audre Lorde Papers, box 66A, courtesy of the Spelman College Archives)

Wright and Campt note Lorde’s foundational impact on the women writers of the Afro-German movement; what also emerges in an exploration of Lorde’s poetic archives is the reciprocal effect that Berlin had on Lorde’s vision of herself. This includes her modes of coping with her own evolving ideas about her work and life. The effect of divided Berlin on Lorde’s sense of self is especially evident given her fragile health and homeopathic treatment, but it can also be seen through her wrestling with her identity as an American in divided Berlin—and the geopolitical complexities of being a traveling black lesbian writer from the United States who forged transnational solidarities and lodged critical inquires through poetry. In the same journal entry from before her trip, she notes, “We are hyphenated people of the Diaspora. … We are an increasingly united front from which the world has not yet heard.”[48] Her mixed grammars of “we” and “they,” along with the presumptive “I” of the journal form, epitomize Lorde’s approach to both poetic and diasporic consciousness—exploring possibilities for connection across lines of identified difference especially through poetic